

Should You Tell Your Employer About Your Arthritis?

Disclosure has pros and cons — a balanced framework.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
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Overview



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Disclosure has pros and cons — a balanced framework.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- **Watch the warning signs.** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]\(/finances\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team from UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. Pending clinical review. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Systematic reviews of workplace interventions for chronic conditions consistently highlight the benefits of early, supportive disclosure to employers. These reviews, which synthesise findings from multiple studies, suggest that employees who feel comfortable discussing their health needs with their managers tend to experience better job retention and reduced symptom interference at work. However, the outcomes are most positive when disclosure is met with genuine understanding and practical adjustments, rather than just a formal acknowledgement.

Clinical guidelines from professional bodies in rheumatology and occupational health also emphasise the importance of good communication. They recommend a proactive approach to managing long-term conditions in the workplace, which often starts with an open conversation between employee and employer. This communication ideally leads to reasonable adjustments that support the employee's health without compromising their ability to perform their job effectively.

Furthermore, observational studies looking at patient experiences often reveal that fear of discrimination or negative impact on career progression can be a significant barrier to disclosure. This underscores the need for clear communication strategies and supportive workplace policies to foster an environment where individuals feel safe and empowered to discuss their chronic conditions. The evidence suggests that while disclosure itself is key, the *context* and *response* to that disclosure are what ultimately determine its effectiveness.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

*** **Waiting until you're struggling badly:**** Don't delay the conversation until your arthritis is severely impacting your work. *** *Fix:** Discuss your condition early, even if symptoms are mild, to allow for proactive planning.

*** **Assuming your employer knows your rights:**** Not all managers are aware of their responsibilities regarding long-term conditions. *** *Fix:** Be prepared to educate your employer about reasonable adjustments and your rights under UK law.

*** **Focusing only on limitations:**** Avoid framing the discussion solely around what you can't do. *** *Fix:** Emphasise solutions and what you *can* do with appropriate support.

*** **Not having a clear idea of what you need:**** Going into the conversation without specific requests can lead to vagueness. *** *Fix:** Think through potential adjustments (e.g., ergonomic equipment, flexible hours) beforehand.

*** **Trying to "power through" without support:****

Ignoring your symptoms can lead to burnout and worsen your condition in the long run. * *Fix: Prioritise your health by seeking support and making necessary changes.*

When to Speak to a Clinician

It's always a good idea to discuss any concerns about your arthritis with your General Practitioner (GP) or rheumatologist, particularly if your condition is impacting your work. They can provide medical advice, help you understand your rights, and suggest strategies for managing your symptoms effectively in a work setting. Don't hesitate to reach out if you experience any of the following:

* A significant worsening or change in your usual arthritis symptoms. * New pain, swelling, or stiffness that lasts more than a few days. * Increased difficulty performing daily tasks or work-related duties. * Side effects from medication that are affecting your ability to work. * You are considering a significant career change or adjustment due to your arthritis.

Frequently Asked Questions

Will telling my employer about my arthritis affect my career progression?

Legally, your employer cannot discriminate against you because of a long-term condition like arthritis. In fact, declaring your condition can allow your employer to make reasonable adjustments that support your work performance and retention, potentially enhancing your career rather than hindering it.

Do I have to tell my employer everything about my medical condition?

You only need to share information that is relevant to your ability to do your job and any reasonable adjustments you might need. You do not have to disclose every detail of your medical history or treatment if it is not pertinent to your work.

What if my employer doesn't offer the adjustments I need?

If discussions with your employer don't lead to satisfactory reasonable adjustments, you can seek advice from an occupational health specialist, a trade union representative, or an employment advisor. There are resources available to help mediate these conversations and ensure your rights are upheld.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about should you tell your employer about your arthritis??

Short answer: The article says telling your employer about arthritis can help if done early and met with understanding, because supportive disclosure may improve job retention, reduce symptom interference and enable reasonable adjustments. It advises discussing concerns with your GP or rheumatologist, tracking symptoms, preparing clear work-related requests, knowing your rights, and seeking help if symptoms worsen.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk